

Becoming more influential in everyday conversations

The Four Communication Styles

- Understand what matters to someone.
- Make your message easier to consider.
- Reach a clear next step while respecting their choice.
- Use these skills at work, at home, in your community, and with customers.



One request can start four different conversations

You suggest changing the location of a family gathering.

- "Can we choose today so I can book it?"
- "What will it cost, and what is included?"
- "Could we turn it into a weekend together?"
- "Will the new location work for everyone?"

Each response gives you something useful to explore.

What you will practice

1. Notice the priority someone expresses.
2. Check your understanding before assuming.
3. Adapt your explanation without changing the facts.
4. Respond to more than one priority.
5. Handle disagreement and agree on a next step.

Success includes an informed, respectful "no."

The four communication styles

Decisive Style

"What can we decide and move forward?"

Evidence-Focused Style

"What information supports this?"

Possibility-Focused Style

"What else could we try?"

Connection-Focused Style

"How will this affect the people involved?"

People can use all four. These are conversation guides, not personality test results.



Decisive style

Possible cues

asks for a recommendation, deadline, or next step.

Helpful response

state the decision, options, and practical consequences.

Keep important risks visible even when time is short.

> Example: "I recommend Saturday. It fits our budget. The deposit is nonrefundable. Shall we decide after everyone replies tonight?"

Check: "Which decision would be most useful to settle now?"



Evidence-focused style

Possible cues

asks about sources, costs, comparisons, or how something works.

Helpful response

explain your reasoning and separate facts from estimates.

Offer time to review what matters.

> Example: "Here are the two quotes and what each includes. We still need to confirm parking charges."

Check: "What information would help you evaluate this?"

Possibility-focused style

Possible cues

suggests alternatives, explores benefits, or builds on an idea.

Helpful response

make room for exploration, then discuss what can be tried.

Agree on how to narrow the options.

> Example: "A weekend could work. What would make it worthwhile? Then we can compare that with a one-day visit."

Check: "Which possibility would you like to explore first?"





Connection-focused style

Possible cues

asks who is affected, raises concerns, or seeks others' input.

Helpful response

listen, explain the impact, and invite honest preferences.

Check agreement rather than assuming silence means yes.

> Example: "Let's ask about travel limits before we book. What might make it difficult for you to join?"

Check: "Whose needs or concerns have we not considered?"

Observation comes before interpretation

Observation

"They asked for the cancellation policy."

Possible interpretation

they need evidence about risk.

Another explanation

a previous booking went wrong.

Useful question

"Is cancellation your main concern, or is there something else?"

One sentence, silence, or speaking speed does not establish a person's style.

Practice tool: Conversation Clues



Your own default approach

When you want agreement, what do you tend to offer first?

A recommendation? Supporting information? New options? Reassurance and involvement?

What does that contribute?

What might the other person still need?

Practice tool: My Communication Habits

Compare two situations. Look for changes as well as patterns.

Blended styles

Two priorities may matter at the same time.

Decisive + Evidence-Focused

"Show me enough to decide."

Decisive + Possibility-Focused

"Let's choose something new to try."

Decisive + Connection-Focused

"Let's agree on a workable next step."

Evidence-Focused + Possibility-Focused

"How could we test that idea?"

Evidence-Focused + Connection-Focused

"What does the feedback tell us?"

Possibility-Focused + Connection-Focused

"What could we create together?"

All pairs are possible. A conversation may involve three or four priorities.

One message can address two priorities

Coworker: "I need a decision today, but I don't want surprises."

Possible response:

> "I recommend a one-week trial. The cost is $200. We have not checked compatibility yet. Can we confirm that by noon and decide at two?"

Notice the decision, evidence, and uncertainty.

Check what "surprises" means to this person.

Practice tool: Blended Priorities Practice

A conversation you can adapt

01

Ask

"What matters most to you here?"

02

Reflect

"So your main concern is..."

03

Offer

explain the proposal using what you learned.

04

Check

"What have I missed?"

05

Agree

decide on an action, further review, or a respectful stop.

The other person's answer can change your proposal as well as your wording.

Adapt your message without hiding the tradeoffs

Proposal: a two-week trial of a new scheduling process.

Facts: a 20-minute setup, no added fee, and a review afterward.

Decisive emphasis

the decision and trial dates.

Evidence emphasis

what we will compare and what remains unknown.

Possibility emphasis

which scheduling problems the trial could address.

Connection emphasis

who will be affected and how they can give feedback.

Every version includes the setup effort and the right to raise concerns.

When the conversation gets difficult

- Notice what changed without assigning a motive.
- Ask about the concern.
- Address the issue before changing your presentation style.

> "We seem to be stuck on the timing. What would make it workable?"

Disagreement may concern the proposal, workload, fairness, or trust.

Better wording cannot fix an unacceptable offer.





Messages and emails need extra care

1. Identify the request and any stated priorities.
2. Consider more than one interpretation.
3. Ask about missing context.
4. Draft a response that preserves facts, limits, and commitments.

Practice tool: Message Response Coach

Use an anonymized sample. Review every draft before sending it.

Practice with an AI partner

01

Choose a conversation: a shared task, a family plan, a community decision, or a customer request.

02

Ask the AI to portray realistic concerns without announcing a style.

03

Have a short conversation.

04

Ask for feedback on your actual words.

05

Repeat one part with a different approach.

The goal is understanding and a workable next step, not winning agreement.

Feedback that helps you improve

Did you ask what mattered?

Did you check your interpretation?

Did your explanation address the stated concern?

Did you keep facts and tradeoffs accurate?

Did you respect disagreement and clarify the next step?

Ask your partner to identify one effective sentence and one sentence to revise.

Why practice adapting your communication

Research on other communication-training programs suggests that learning to adapt how we communicate can help strengthen working relationships.

Our practice asks a practical question:

Did your revised approach make the conversation clearer and address what mattered?

Source example: TRACOM's published findings for its SOCIAL STYLE® training.

Those findings concern that program, not this course. No affiliation or endorsement is implied.

https://tracom.com/social-style-training

Your next conversation

01

Choose one real conversation.

02

Write the outcome you hope for.

03

List what you know and what you still need to ask.

04

Prepare an opening question and a short explanation.

05

Afterward, record what you learned and what you would change.

You can use all four styles.

Start with the person's expressed needs and stay willing to adjust.